Where Planning Ahead for Mom Begins: Step One of Nine, and What Comes After It

The nine steps of the Medicaid Planning Roadmap, with yours marked.

Planning ahead for Mom's care can sound like one enormous job. It's nine steps, and you're on the first.

This page shows the whole road, where you are on it, and who is involved after this step.

Phase 1 · Assess

Understand where you are today.

1 **Understand** Care Needs → Levels of Care & Costs → Care Plan
You finish with: Future Care Planning Assessment

You are here. This step is about understanding Mom's care needs: how she is doing today, how her needs may change, what she would want, and what kinds of care exist. You finish your part of it with today's picture, the help already in place, her wishes in her own words and your open questions written down.

2 **Organize** Income & Assets → Ownership & Expenses → Financial File
You finish with: Family Financial Inventory

3 **Assess** Care & Nonfinancial Eligibility → Income & Assets → Barriers & Readiness
You finish with: Medicaid Readiness Assessment

Phase 2 · Plan

Develop and implement your strategy.

4 **Plan** Barriers & Issues → Priorities & Professional Team → Written Plan
You finish with: Advance Medicaid Planning Roadmap

5 **Legal** Authority & Documents → Property, Trusts & Transfers → Attorney Review
You finish with: Legal Planning Review

6 **Financial** Costs & Runway → Asset Treatment & Tools → Strategy & Documentation
You finish with: Long-Term Care Funding Plan

Phase 3 · Secure

Secure benefits, protect assets, and maintain eligibility.

7 **Apply** Prepare → Submit → Manage
You finish with: Medicaid Application-Ready File

8 **Protect** What May Be Protected → What May Remain Exposed → What Needs Ongoing Attention
You finish with: Asset Protection Assessment

9 **Maintain** Ongoing Requirements → Changes & Renewals → Maintenance System

You finish with: Medicaid Monitoring & Maintenance System

What this step produces

A written picture of Mom's care: how she is doing day to day, the help she already has, what she has told you she wants, and the questions that are still open. It is a family's understanding, organized. It isn't a clinical assessment, and it decides nothing.

What happens next

The step after this one is Organize: the family's income, assets and expenses, gathered into one financial file. Then comes Assess, and after that the steps for planning, legal and financial work, the application and what follows it, each worked through with the right professional. The picture of Mom's care you build now is where all of them start.

Medicaid is a joint federal and state program, and its eligibility rules and the services it covers vary from state to state. That is why nothing on this page states a rule, and why the later steps are worked through with a professional who knows your state. [1]

Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: noticing, asking, writing down.
- Mom: her own account of how she is doing and what she would want.
- Her doctor, her pharmacist and her other care providers: the questions about her health, and what any change means.
- At this step, your Medicaid planner: reviews your family's picture of Mom's current needs, everyday functioning and care preferences, helps you line up your questions about care options and costs for her care providers, and notes the changes that would call for a fresh look.
- In later steps: an elder law attorney for legal advice and legal documents, licensed insurance and financial professionals for insurance and investment products, and an applications specialist for the application.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. Families move through the steps at different speeds. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know where you are and what comes after it. The care interview is how you get this step under way: it walks you through Mom's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. The statement that Medicaid's rules vary from state to state is the Administration for Community Living's.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid